Exit tickets

Identifying what needs revisiting

Use an exit ticket when a brief independent response can inform the next lesson. Choose essential knowledge and a format that can be reviewed quickly.

How to do it well

1 Choose the purpose. Identify the essential idea or prerequisite you need to inspect before the next lesson.

2 Write a short prompt. Use a bounded explanation, diagnostic choice, diagram or small performance that reveals the target knowledge.

3 Allow an independent response. Reserve enough time and keep the solution hidden until students have committed.

4 Divide and inspect. Sort by quality of understanding, then look closely at the main error patterns and selected unclear answers.

5 Decide the next lesson response. Plan a fresh retrieval or diagnostic prompt and the explanation, rehearsal or support the evidence warrants.

What this sounds like

“Before you leave, answer this alone: which example shows diffusion, and which feature tells you? Include one sentence explaining your choice.”

Classroom example. A Computing exit ticket asks pupils to predict the output of a short, taught code structure and explain one decision. The teacher sorts the answers and finds a common misunderstanding. The next lesson begins with a related check and a short repair, rather than starting new content over an unresolved prerequisite.

Top tips that make the technique work

Keep the ticket narrow. One useful conceptual distinction may reveal more than five broad questions.

Include reasoning where necessary. A letter choice alone can hide why the student selected it.

Protect independence. A ticket copied after class discussion gives less information about the individual’s understanding.

Sort before annotating. Group responses by secure, partly secure and insecure, then inspect the causes of difficulty.

Prepare the next move. Decide whether tomorrow needs retrieval, a brief clarification, guided practice or a fuller reteach.

Do and avoid

Do	Avoid
Target the learning that matters for the next lesson.	Collecting tickets without reviewing them.
Use the responses to plan teaching.	A long end-of-lesson assessment with no time to complete it.

Further reading

Practitioner guidance; teacher language above is an illustrative BSCS adaptation.

DistillED - Exit Tickets | Barton - Diagnostic questions as exit tickets